

Running the Academy

How to do everything yourself: enrol people, see who is struggling, post a notice, add a video, print the workbook. Written for the person teaching, not the person who built it.

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Start here

Go to **smarttaxiq.com/academy** and type your email address. A six-digit code arrives; type it in. There is no password, so there is nothing to forget and nothing to reset.

Once you are in, four links sit along the top of the page. They are the whole system.

LINK	WHAT IT IS FOR
Instructor view	Who is on track and who has gone quiet. The page you check twice a week.
Teaching	Add a video to a module, leave a note, or send a notice to everyone.
Roster	Add people, remove people, approve requests to join.
Materials	Every PDF, including the ones only you can see. Print from here.

THE ONE THING TO UNDERSTAND ABOUT ACCESS

A person can sign in if, and only if, their email address is on your roster. Nobody can sign themselves up, and nobody outside the roster can see a single page of the course.

So when a trainee says “it won’t let me in”, the answer is almost always that their address is spelled differently from the one you typed. Check the roster first, every time, before anything else.

Getting people in

Roster → Add someone. Takes about twenty seconds per person.

Adding a trainee

1. Open **Roster**.
2. Type their first name, last name and email address.
3. Leave the role on **Trainee**.
4. Click **Add to roster**.

THEY GET NO EMAIL FROM THIS

Adding someone is silent on purpose. Send them the link yourself — a text or a WhatsApp message works — and tell them to use the exact address you entered.

Something like: *"You're set up. Go to smarttaxiq.com/academy, enter [their address], and a code comes to your email. Start with Module 0."*

Someone who asks to join

If a person reaches the sign-in page and their address is not on the roster, they are told so plainly and offered a short form. Those requests appear at the top of your Roster page with their name, their email and anything they wrote.

Add to roster enrolls them. **Dismiss** files it away. You also get an email each time one arrives, so you do not have to go looking.

Taking someone off

Withdraw on their row. It does not delete anything — their scores stay, they lose access the next time they load a page, and **Reinstate** puts everything back. Use it for somebody who drops out rather than deleting them, because people come back.

MAKING SOMEONE ELSE AN INSTRUCTOR

The role picker has an **Instructor** option. It gives that person everything you have: every student's scores, the answer keys, and the ability to add and remove people. Only use it for someone who should have all three.

JOB TWO

Seeing who is in trouble

Instructor view. The most useful four seconds of your week.

One row per trainee, one column per module, and a last-seen column. Read it like this:

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
A grey dash	They have not attempted that module's check at all.	Chase it. Usually they have not started the module.
Red, a day after you taught it	Attempted, under 70%.	Nothing yet. Retakes are unlimited and most people pass on the second go.
Red, still red a week later	They have stopped trying.	Thirty minutes one-to-one. This is the signal, not the red itself.
Last seen in red	Nine days or more since they opened the course.	Call them. Not a message — a call. This one predicts dropouts better than any score.
A high try count	Passed, but it took five attempts.	Worth a quiet word. They are getting there by elimination, not by understanding.

WHAT THESE SCORES ARE NOT

Knowledge-check scores measure **engagement**. They do not measure whether somebody can prepare a return, and they are not the thing that decides who works the season.

That decision comes from the six assignments, the four practice returns and the December exam — all on paper, all marked by you, all with the rubric in the Instructor Pack. The dashboard tells you who to worry about. Your marking tells you who is ready.

JOB THREE

Talking to the class

Teaching → Announcements.

Type what you want to say and click **Post it**. It appears at the top of the course page for everyone, straight away.

Leave **Email it to the trainees as well** ticked and each person also gets it by email — one message each, so nobody sees anyone else's address and a reply comes to you rather than to all five.

WHEN TO TICK THE EMAIL BOX

Tick it for anything time-sensitive: a session moving, a deadline, a cancellation, anything they need before they next sit down.

Leave it off for something that can wait until they next open the course: a reading suggestion, encouragement, a note about next week. Five emails in a week and they stop reading the sixth.

Taking one down

Take it down hides it from students. It does not unsend the email — nothing can — and it does not delete the record. Use it when a notice has gone stale rather than letting four weeks of old notices stack up at the top of the course.

JOB FOUR

Adding a video

Teaching → Videos & module notes.

Record wherever you like — your phone, a Zoom recording, anything. Upload it to YouTube or Vimeo, copy the link, and paste it into the module it belongs to.

1. On YouTube, set the video to **Unlisted**. That means only people with the link can watch it, which is what you want: it keeps the class private without making you manage permissions.
2. Copy the link from the **Share** button.
3. Paste it into the **Video link** box for that module.
4. Add a label if it helps — “Watch before Tuesday” — and click **Save**.

Students see the video at the top of that module next time they open it. Clear the box and save to take it away again.

A ZOOM RECORDING WORKS TOO

Record the session in Zoom, upload the file to YouTube as Unlisted, paste the link. The people who missed Tuesday catch up without you teaching it twice, and by Week 10 you have a library you can reuse next year.

The note box

Underneath the video link is a note. It appears above that module’s teaching, and it is for things that are true this week only: *“We’ll do the scenarios together on Thursday — try them first”*.

WHAT YOU CANNOT CHANGE YOURSELF

The teaching text of each module, and the knowledge-check questions.

Those live in the website’s code rather than in a box you can edit, because the quizzes depend on their exact structure — an editing box over the top of them is the most reliable way to break a check the week before an exam.

So a wording change, a new scenario, a corrected figure: send it to Mikel. It is usually same-day. What you can change without anyone — videos, notes, notices, the roster — covers the things that actually move week to week.

MATERIALS

Printing

Materials. Everything opens in your browser's PDF viewer, so printing is Ctrl-P from there.

DOCUMENT	WHO SEES IT	WHEN TO PRINT
Student Workbook — 34pp	Everyone	Once per trainee, before Week 1. Double-sided.
Practice Returns — 17pp	Everyone	Week 10. One set each.
Instructor Pack — 45pp	You only	Once, now. Keep it beside you all ten weeks.
Practice Returns solutions — 12pp	You only	Week 10, for marking.
Final Exam — 9pp	You only	The morning of the exam, not before.
Exam key and marking sheet — 18pp	You only	After they have sat it.

THE FOUR INSTRUCTOR DOCUMENTS ARE INVISIBLE TO TRAINEES

Not locked, not greyed out — simply not on the page when a trainee looks at it, and not reachable even if someone guessed the address. A visible locked door invites somebody to try the handle.

Which puts the risk back where it belongs: on paper. The exam key contains Paper B, the retake set. Do not leave it on the desk.

THREE WAYS TO TEACH IT

Same course, three rooms

You asked whether you could teach this online, over Zoom and in person without rebuilding it. You can, and here is what changes in each.

	SELF-PACED ONLINE	OVER ZOOM	IN PERSON
They read	The course page, on their own	The course page before the call	The printed workbook
You teach from	Nothing live — videos instead	Instructor Pack run sheets, screen-sharing the course page	Instructor Pack run sheets
Scenarios	They reveal the answers themselves	Breakout pairs, then debrief	Pairs in the room, then debrief
Knowledge checks	On the course page, any time	On the course page, last 15 minutes	On the course page, on their phones
You watch	Instructor view	Instructor view	Instructor view
Extra work for you	Record a video per module	None	Print the workbooks

THE THING THAT MAKES ALL THREE WORK

The knowledge checks live online in every version. Whether somebody studied alone at midnight or sat in your office on a Tuesday, their score lands in the same place and you read the same dashboard.

So you can run a mixed cohort — two in the office, three remote — without running two courses. Which is exactly what this intake is.

BEFORE 16 OCTOBER

Fifteen days to comfortable

An hour a day gets you to where nothing on the platform surprises you. In order.

DAYS	DO THIS	WHY
1–2	Sign in. Click all four links. Add yourself a fake trainee with a second email address and sign in as them in a private window.	Seeing the student side is the fastest way to understand the instructor side.
3–4	As that fake trainee, take Module 0's knowledge check. Get one wrong on purpose. Then look at Instructor view.	Now the dashboard means something. You have seen where a score comes from.
5–6	Open Materials. Print the Instructor Pack. Read Module 0 and Module 1's run sheets.	This is the document you will actually teach from. It should not be new on the day.
7–8	Post a test announcement with the email box ticked. Check it arrives at your fake trainee's address.	You will need this in week one and you do not want to learn it then.
9–10	Record a two-minute welcome video on your phone. Upload it Unlisted. Paste it into Module 0.	The whole video flow, once, with nothing at stake.
11–12	Print one workbook. Sit down and work through Module 2's four filing-status scenarios as a student would.	Module 2 is 30% of the exam and the one trainees fail. Know it cold.
13–14	Confirm the five figures on the verify list. Check your trainees are all on the roster and can sign in.	The two things that actually stop a first class going ahead.
15	Delete the fake trainee. Post a real welcome notice.	You are ready.

IF SOMETHING BREAKS ON THE DAY

A trainee cannot sign in. Check the roster for a typo in their address. That is the cause nine times out of ten.

A code did not arrive. Spam folder first. Then have them click *Send another code* — codes expire after fifteen minutes.

A score did not save. The page says so plainly if it fails. Have them take the check again; nothing is lost.

Anything else. Message Mikel, and teach from the printed Instructor Pack in the meantime. The paper version of this course works with no website at all — that is deliberate.

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Tax year 2026 edition, for returns filed in 2027. Every figure in this document is checked against IRS and State of Michigan sources each October; confirm the figures sheet before the module that uses it. Training material, not tax or legal advice.